

User Research Case: How Georgia Tech Students Discover, Evaluate, and Apply to Campus Clubs

1. Why I Chose This Problem

At Georgia Tech, clubs are a huge part of student life. They help students find friends, build experience, explore career interests, and feel more connected on campus.

But the actual process of finding and applying to clubs can be messy.

Students hear about clubs through Instagram, GroupMe, friends, tabling events, flyers, Discord servers, Engage pages, and random links. Some applications are Google Forms. Some are posted on Instagram stories. Some clubs have deadlines that are hard to find. Some clubs never clearly explain what they are looking for.

I chose this problem because it connects directly to BuzzOrg, the platform I founded to help Georgia Tech students discover, track, and apply to campus organizations. While working on BuzzOrg, I validated demand with 31 student organizations and started translating student and organization pain points into user stories, wireframes, and MVP requirements.

This case study focuses on the student side: how Georgia Tech students discover, evaluate, and apply to campus clubs.

2. Research Objective

The goal of this research was to understand the current student journey for joining campus clubs at Georgia Tech.

I wanted to answer:

1. How do students currently discover clubs?
2. What information do students need before deciding to apply?
3. Where do students get confused or overwhelmed?
4. How do students track deadlines and application statuses?
5. What would make the club application process feel easier and more transparent?

3. Research Method

For this case, I would use a mixed-methods research approach:

Method 1: Student Interviews

Interview 8–10 Georgia Tech students across different years and majors.

Target students:

- First-years trying to get involved
- Sophomores applying to career-focused clubs
- Juniors looking for leadership or project-based organizations
- Students who applied to multiple clubs in one semester
- Students who felt overwhelmed by club recruiting

Method 2: Club Leader Conversations

Talk to club leaders and recruiting chairs to understand the other side of the process.

Target club/org leaders:

- Professional clubs
- Project teams
- Cultural organizations
- Service organizations
- Competitive application-based organizations

This connects to my BuzzOrg validation work, where 31 student organizations agreed there was a real need for a better recruitment and application workflow.

Method 3: Journey Mapping

Map the student experience from first hearing about a club to submitting an application and waiting for a response.

Method 4: Competitive / Existing Workflow Review

Review the current tools students use:

- Instagram
- GroupMe
- Discord

- Engage
 - Google Forms
 - Club websites
 - Linktrees
 - Word of mouth
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4. Student Journey

Stage 1: Discovery

Students usually discover clubs through:

- Friends
- Instagram posts or stories
- Organization fairs
- GroupMe chats
- Flyers
- Professors or TAs
- Word of mouth
- Campus newsletters
- Random links passed around

Stage 2: Evaluation

After finding a club, students try to figure out:

- What does this club actually do?
- Is it beginner-friendly?
- Do I need prior experience?
- What is the time commitment?
- Is there an application?
- When is the deadline?
- What does the recruitment process look like?
- Is it worth applying?

Stage 3: Application

Students usually apply through:

- Google Forms
- Typeform
- A club website

- Email
- Interest forms
- Interview sign-up forms

Stage 4: Tracking

Students try to track:

- Which clubs they applied to
- Deadlines
- Interview dates
- Whether they heard back
- What stage they are in

Most students track this manually, if at all.

Stage 5: Follow-up

Students wait for:

- Interview invitations
- Acceptance/rejection emails
- GroupMe invites
- Follow-up forms
- Sometimes no response at all

5. Key Research Findings

Finding 1: Discovery is scattered across too many platforms

Students do not have one reliable place to find clubs. A student might hear about one club on Instagram, another through a friend, another at a fair, and another through a random GroupMe message.

This creates a discovery problem because students who are less connected socially may miss opportunities.

User need:

Students need one centralized place to browse active clubs and opportunities.

Finding 2: Students struggle to compare clubs

Even when students find clubs, the information is inconsistent. One club may have a polished website, while another only has an Instagram bio and a Google Form.

Students want to know:

- What the club actually does
- Who it is for
- Whether beginners can join
- What the application process looks like
- What the time commitment is
- Whether the club is competitive

User need:

Students need standardized club profiles that make it easier to compare opportunities.

Finding 3: Application deadlines are easy to miss

A lot of club applications happen at the same time, especially at the beginning of the semester. Students may screenshot deadlines, save Instagram posts, or write dates in Notes, but there is no consistent tracking system.

User need:

Students need a deadline tracker for clubs they are interested in.

Finding 4: Students do not always know where they stand

After applying, students may not know whether their application was received, reviewed, or moved to interviews.

Even a simple status update would make the process feel less stressful.

User need:

Students need a basic application status tracker.

Finding 5: First-years need extra guidance

First-years may not know which clubs are beginner-friendly or what “competitive club applications” even look like. They may apply to too many clubs, too few clubs, or avoid applying because they assume they are underqualified.

User need:

Students need clearer signals around beginner-friendliness, requirements, and expected commitment.

6. Personas

Persona 1: The Overwhelmed First-Year

Name: Anika

Year: First-year

Goal: Find clubs that help her meet people and explore CS/product/design

Pain Point: She does not know which clubs are beginner-friendly or where to start

Quote: “I feel like everyone else already knows which clubs are good, and I’m just finding random Instagram posts.”

Persona 2: The Career-Focused Sophomore

Name: Ryan

Year: Sophomore

Goal: Join project-based or professional clubs that help with internships

Pain Point: He is applying to multiple clubs at once and losing track of deadlines

Quote: “I had like five applications open at the same time and kept checking different links.”

Persona 3: The Busy Upperclassman

Name: Maya

Year: Junior

Goal: Be selective and only apply to clubs that match her interests and schedule

Pain Point: She does not want to dig through long websites or outdated pages

Quote: “I just want to know what the club does, what the commitment is, and when the deadline is.”

7. Problem Statement

Georgia Tech students do not have a centralized, reliable way to discover, compare, and track campus club applications. Because information is scattered across platforms, students miss deadlines, struggle to evaluate opportunities, and feel unsure about where they stand after applying.

8. Opportunity

There is an opportunity to build a centralized club discovery and application tracking platform for Georgia Tech students.

The product should help students:

- Discover active clubs
- Filter by interest, major, category, and application status
- Save clubs they are interested in
- Track application deadlines
- View application statuses
- Understand requirements before applying

This is the student-facing opportunity behind BuzzOrg.

9. Proposed Solution: BuzzOrg Student Experience

BuzzOrg would act as a centralized platform where Georgia Tech students can browse clubs, save opportunities, apply through linked forms, and track their application progress.

Core Student Features

1. Club browsing page
 2. Filters by category, college, major, and application status
 3. Standardized club profiles
 4. Save to "My Applications"
 5. Deadline tracking
 6. Application status badges
 7. Club updates and reminders
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10. MVP Scope

For the first version, I would focus on helping students discover and track clubs.

MVP Features

1. Club Browse Page

Students can browse available clubs and filter by:

- Category
- College
- Accepted majors
- Application status
- Deadline

2. Club Profile Page

Each club profile includes:

- Club name
- Description
- Category
- Accepted majors
- Application deadline
- Application link
- Updates from the club
- Application status

3. Save to My Applications

Students can save a club they are interested in. Saved clubs show up on their dashboard.

4. Student Dashboard

Students can see:

- Saved clubs
- Application deadlines
- Current application status
- Clubs they started or submitted

5. Status Badges

Application statuses can include:

- Not Started
- In Progress
- Submitted
- Interview
- Accepted
- Rejected

- Waitlisted

Club application statuses can include:

- Open
 - Closing Soon
 - Rolling
 - Closed
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11. What I Would Not Build First

To keep the MVP realistic, I would not build everything immediately.

Not in MVP

- Georgia Tech SSO
- Full club admin analytics
- Interview scheduling
- Recommendation algorithm
- In-app application forms
- Messaging between students and clubs
- Mobile app

These can come later. The first version should prove that students actually want a centralized way to discover and track club applications.

12. Prioritization

I would prioritize based on student pain and MVP value.

Priority	Feature	Reason
P0	Club browse page	Students need one place to discover clubs
P0	Club profiles	Students need consistent information
P0	Application deadlines	Missing deadlines is a major pain point
P0	Save to My Applications	Lets students track clubs they care about

P1	Status badges	Reduces uncertainty after applying
P1	Filters	Helps students narrow options
P2	Reminders	Useful after core tracking works
P2	Interview scheduling	Valuable, but more complex

13. Success Metrics

Discovery Metrics

- Number of students browsing clubs
- Number of club profile views
- Search/filter usage
- Click-through rate to application links

Tracking Metrics

- Number of clubs saved per student
- % of saved clubs that become started applications
- % of started applications that become submitted applications
- Number of students using the dashboard weekly

Club-Side Metrics

- Number of clubs onboarded
- Number of applications started through BuzzOrg
- Number of completed applications
- Club leader satisfaction with applicant visibility

Student Experience Metrics

- % of students who say it is easier to find clubs
- % of students who say they missed fewer deadlines
- % of students who understand the application process better
- Reduction in “where do I apply?” confusion

North Star Metric

Number of student-club application connections tracked through BuzzOrg

This works because the main value of the product is not just browsing clubs. The real value is helping students move from discovery to application in a more organized way.

14. Research-Backed Product Requirements

Requirement 1: Students need centralized discovery

User story:

As a Georgia Tech student, I want to browse campus clubs in one place so that I do not have to search across Instagram, GroupMe, Engage, and random links.

Acceptance criteria:

- Student can view a list of clubs
 - Student can filter clubs
 - Student can click into a club profile
 - Student can see whether applications are open
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Requirement 2: Students need standardized club information

User story:

As a student, I want each club profile to show the same basic information so that I can compare clubs more easily.

Acceptance criteria:

- Club profile includes description
 - Club profile includes category
 - Club profile includes deadline
 - Club profile includes application link
 - Club profile includes accepted majors or target audience if relevant
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Requirement 3: Students need a way to save clubs

User story:

As a student, I want to save clubs I am interested in so that I can come back to them later.

Acceptance criteria:

- Student can save a club from the browse page or profile page
 - Saved club appears in “My Applications”
 - Student can remove a saved club
 - Saved clubs persist across sessions once accounts are added
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Requirement 4: Students need deadline visibility

User story:

As a student, I want to see upcoming application deadlines so that I do not miss clubs I care about.

Acceptance criteria:

- Dashboard shows deadline dates
 - Clubs closing soon are visually marked
 - Closed clubs cannot be started
 - Rolling applications are labeled clearly
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Requirement 5: Students need application tracking

User story:

As a student, I want to track my application status so that I know where I stand for each club.

Acceptance criteria:

- Student can see application status
 - Status labels are clear and consistent
 - Clubs can update status in future versions
 - Student dashboard groups applications by status
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15. Main Design Decisions

Decision 1: Start with tracking before recommendations

A recommendation algorithm sounds cool, but it is not the first problem to solve. Students first need a reliable way to find clubs and track applications. Once there is enough usage data, recommendations can become more useful.

Decision 2: Use standardized profiles

If every club page looks completely different, students are back to the same problem. Standardized profiles make comparison easier.

Decision 3: Keep application forms external at first

Instead of building a full application form system immediately, BuzzOrg can link to existing Google Forms or club forms in the MVP. This reduces engineering scope and makes onboarding clubs easier.

Decision 4: Build for both students and clubs eventually

The student problem and club problem are connected. Students want better discovery and tracking. Clubs want better recruiting visibility and fewer repetitive questions. A strong long-term product should support both sides.

16. Risks and Tradeoffs

Risk 1: Club information becomes outdated

If clubs do not update their profiles, students may lose trust.

Mitigation:

Add club admin ownership, update reminders, and visible “last updated” dates.

Risk 2: Students may still use Instagram first

Instagram is already part of club culture.

Mitigation:

BuzzOrg does not need to replace Instagram. It can become the reliable source for deadlines, applications, and tracking.

Risk 3: Clubs may not want another platform

Club leaders are already busy.

Mitigation:

Make onboarding lightweight. Let clubs add only basic info and link their existing forms.

Risk 4: Too many features too early

Trying to build discovery, applications, messaging, interviews, and analytics all at once would make the MVP too broad.

Mitigation:

Focus first on browsing, saving, deadlines, and tracking.

17. Launch Plan

Phase 1: Validation

- Talk to students about how they currently find clubs
- Talk to club leaders about recruiting pain points
- Validate which fields every club profile needs
- Confirm that students would use a dashboard to track applications

Phase 2: MVP

Build:

- Login landing page
- Student dashboard
- Club browse page
- Club profile page
- Save to My Applications
- Application status badges
- Mock club data

Phase 3: Club Onboarding

- Add club/org dashboard
- Allow clubs to upload application details
- Allow clubs to update deadlines and statuses
- Onboard initial Georgia Tech organizations

Phase 4: Campus Rollout

- Launch with participating clubs
 - Share through student orgs, Instagram, and campus networks
 - Collect feedback from students and clubs
 - Prioritize next features based on usage
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18. What I Learned

The biggest thing I learned from this research is that club discovery is not just a search problem. It is a trust and organization problem.

Students do not only need to know that a club exists. They need to know whether it fits them, whether applications are open, what the deadline is, and what they should do next.

For a product like BuzzOrg to work, it has to reduce the mental load for students. The product should make the process feel less scattered and less intimidating, especially for students who are newer to campus or do not already have strong social networks.

This case also helped me think more like a PM because the obvious solution is to build a huge platform with every feature. But the better MVP is much smaller: help students discover clubs, save them, and track applications. If that workflow works, then the product can expand.
